

CHRISTENDOM COLLEGE

CHRISTENDOM COLLEGE ONLINE LEARNING

The History of Western Political Thought

Lecture 1: Teleology and the Common Good in the Writings of Aristotle

Introduction

>> Greetings from Christendom College. Welcome to this principles class on the history of Western political thought. My name is Dr. Joseph Bruto. I am an assistant professor of political science here at Christendom as well as the chairman of the political science department. Christendom College is a small lay run liberal arts college in the Shenandoah Valley of Northern Virginia whose education strives to be faithful to the magisterium of the Catholic Church as outlined by Pope St. John Paul II in *ex corde ecclesiae*. It is my privilege to deliver these series of lectures to you on the history of Western political thought. In this course of lectures I hope to cover the history of Western political thought beginning in the ancient Greek world and ending in 19th century America. Obviously that will cover a wide stretch of time and we will only be able to look at small snippets of this history. Nonetheless I hope that after you have viewed all of these lectures you have a better understanding of the Western political tradition that informs much of contemporary thinking about political matters. This first class is titled "Teleology and the Common Good in the Writings of Aristotle." In this class I will introduce you to the political philosopher Aristotle and give you a brief introduction to his views on ethics and politics. So let's begin with a little bit of background.

The political philosopher Aristotle lived from 385 to 322 BC. He did most of his important work in and around ancient Athens. As some of you may know from a previous philosophy class, he was the most famous student of the political philosopher Plato. He studied under Plato at his famous academy and in his later years founded a school of his own known as the Lyceum.

Now Aristotle lived and wrote and worked at a time when it was possible for a man to know a little bit about everything. We think of Aristotle primarily as a philosopher and rightly so, but he was also a biologist, a scientist, a meteorologist, an economist and even a theologian of a sort. Now obviously it's not possible to consider Aristotle's writings and his works in all of these areas. So in this class I am going to focus on what we tend to call Aristotle's practical philosophy, which means his writings and his work on ethics and

politics. I'm going to begin with Aristotle's work on ethics because it is in that work that he tells us important things about what a human being is, what human nature is and what it means to live a good human life. After we have a basic overview of Aristotle's understanding of these matters, we can then move on to look at what he has to say about how individual human lives connect to or hook up with communal lives, the lives that we live in common in our political communities. Now when focusing on Aristotle's ethics, we have a number of sources that we can turn to. Thankfully for us, the most important and most famous of these sources is Aristotle's famous work that comes to us under the title of the Nicomachean Ethics. Now the Nicomachean Ethics presents a modern reader with a few problems. One of these problems is that the work is not written in the way a traditional book or a philosophical treatise would be written. We believe that this work, at least in the form that we possess it, comes to us as a series of lecture notes, a series of detailed lecture notes from a number of classes that Aristotle would have delivered to his students at the school that I mentioned earlier, the Lyceum. Now students often wonder why this work is called the Nicomachean Ethics and the truth is that scholars and philosophers aren't really sure. There are a couple of competing theories about this title. Some say that this work was dedicated to Aristotle's son, Nicomache's. Others say that the work was sort of compiled and collated by his son, Nicomache's, after Aristotle's death. But whatever the case may be, this is the most important work on ethics that Aristotle composes and one of the most important works on ethics in the last two plus millennia of Western philosophy. So before diving into the work, I would like to say a little bit of something about what this work is about. And very briefly and simply, what Aristotle does in the 10 books that make up this work known as the Nicomachean Ethics, he looks at the nature of human action

The Nature of Human Actions

and the nature of human decision making. He emphasizes what he calls virtue and he divides virtue into two categories, the moral virtues, which are virtues of character, virtues that govern action and the intellectual virtues, those virtues that govern thought. So I am going to begin our study of the Nicomachean Ethics by giving you a quote from the very beginning of the very first book of the work.

Aristotle starts this work with the famous following sentence. Quote, "Every art and every inquiry and similarly every action as well as choice is held to aim at some good. Hence, people have nobly declared that the good is that at which all things aim." Now I want to say a little bit about what Aristotle is doing in this quote. The word that we use here in English is the word good. Every action that we perform, every choice that we make, Aristotle says, is held to aim at some good. Now the Greek word that is being translated into English as good is the word telos. What does the word telos mean? Well, it can be understood as the

translator here understands it as good, but it can also mean end goal or purpose. And so what Aristotle is trying to communicate in this brief sentence is an idea that is very simple, yet nonetheless very profound. He is telling his audience and by extension he is telling us that everything we make, everything that we study, everything that we do and everything that we choose, we make, study, do and choose with some end or purpose or goal or good in mind. In other words, we don't just do things randomly for random reasons, everything that we do, whether we realize it or not, whether we're always conscious of it or not, we do with a reason and purpose in mind. So when I'm articulating this lesson to my students in class here at Christendom, I make the point by asking them a series of questions. One of the questions that I often like to ask students is why did you choose to come and get an education here at Christendom College? And you'll get various answers because I want to get a job, because I value education for my own sake, because my parents made me do it. And then when a student answers a question in whatever way he or she answers it, I can always ask a series of further questions. Okay, I might say, you've chosen to get an education because you want to get a job. Why is it that you want to get a job? The student might say because I want to make money.

Why is it that you want to make money? Because I want to be able to support my family. Why is it that you want to be able to raise and support a family? And as you see, these questions can go on and on. Now, just to clarify and to sort of clear up a potential misunderstanding, when Aristotle says that we do everything for a good, when we do everything with an end or a purpose in mind, he's not necessarily saying that that which we aim at, he's not necessarily saying that our purposes are always objectively good as opposed to bad. One way that philosophers like to talk about this is to say that everything that we do, we do with some good in mind, whether that good is in fact a real good or simply something that is perceived as good, whether or not we may be mistaken. So this is the structure according to Aristotle of human reason, of human decision making, and of human action. Now, if you refer back to that series of hypothetical questions that I might ask my students, you'll notice that that series of questions kind of goes on and on. For every choice that we make, for every reason that we give, we can always ask a further question and elicit a further reason as to why you choose to do that. However, it's important for Aristotle that this chain of reasoning or this chain of purposes, you might say, does not go on infinitely, it does not go on forever. It is true that we do one thing for the sake of another, for the sake of another, etc, etc.

But this chain of reasoning does need to come to a stop at some point. Another image I would often use here with my students, one that may be familiar to you, is the image of Russian nesting dolls. You open up the big one and there's a smaller one inside, and you

open up that one and there's a smaller one inside. But eventually you get to one smallest one that you can't open up and sort of discover another doll in.

And the same idea is at work here. You do certain things for the sake of other things, but ultimately according to Aristotle, and this is quite important, there is one thing, one ultimate thing we might say, that we do or that we choose for its own sake and not for the sake of something else. This chain of reasoning, this chain of choices, this chain of actions needs to end somewhere. And in the *Nicomachean Ethics*, Aristotle thinks that it's quite important for us to examine what this ultimate thing is. What is this thing that we choose or do for its own sake and not for the sake of something else? And here I have to introduce you to another Greek word that Aristotle uses.

Aristotle calls this thing, this thing that we choose for its own sake and not for the sake of something else. He calls it in Greek, *eudaimonia*. Now again, as with all translations, there's a bit of a difficulty here in rendering this word into English. The most common translation of this word would be happiness. Now I can tell you personally that that's not my preferred translation of the word.

Because I think that in contemporary times, happiness has a different connotation to it than the one Aristotle intended. For us, happiness is something subjective. If I want to know if you are happy, I simply have to ask you, do you feel happy today? And if you tell me yes, then I know that you are happy.

Eudaimonia, by contrast, for Aristotle isn't something subjective. It doesn't depend on how you or I feel at any given moment. Rather, it is what he calls an objective state of the soul. You have achieved this state or you have not, independently of what your feelings or emotions might be at any given moment. And so the translation of this word into English that I prefer, instead of happiness, would be flourishing. Because I think the word flourishing in English gives us a sense of whether or not something is living up to its potential, independent of how that person or that thing might feel.

So after Aristotle explains the name of this ultimate human good, he wants to say something about the content of it. What precisely is this thing? Now, Aristotle, in the *Nicomachean Ethics*, he goes through a number of different candidates. And I'm just going to run briefly through some of those with you. Aristotle points out that some people say that this highest human good is pleasure.

And he dismisses that pretty quickly because he says, "Look, there's nothing unique about pleasure, or rather there's nothing uniquely human about pleasure. Other animals experience that too." Okay, well, others say maybe this highest human good is money or wealth. Well, Aristotle says, "We don't really desire money or wealth for its own sake. We

desire money or wealth because of what it is capable of getting us. So it can't be that one ultimate thing that we desire for its own sake." Other people, Aristotle says, say that this highest human good would be to be honored by others. This at first glance may be a more promising candidate, but Aristotle rejects it too, because he says that whatever the highest human good is cannot necessarily depend upon others, but must be something that we are capable of attaining or achieving ourselves. If other people give us honor, other people can take that honor away from us, and this highest human good, this *udaimonia*, this flourishing, should not be dependent upon others.

Aristotle's Function Argument

So then we might ask, how is it that we are to determine what human flourishing consists in? And Aristotle has a little procedure here that he makes use of. Philosophers call this the function argument. Aristotle asks of his audience. He says, "Look at human beings in general. Can we identify some unique activity that human beings and human beings alone are capable of doing? Something that we do not share with other animals? Something that depends on us? Something that is not dependent upon others? And something that is desired or useful for its own sake, and not desired or useful for the sake of something else. And after running through a number of different options, Aristotle tells us quite cogently that this unique thing that human beings and human beings alone are capable of doing is engaging in rational activity. We are unique among the creatures in that we possess a faculty of reason and are capable of engaging in rational thought. And so to summarize a lot of complex material, Aristotle says that human *udaimonia* or human flourishing consists in what he calls rational activity of the soul in accord with virtue. And if you want an easier way to think about that in English, we may call that contemplation or philosophical contemplation, contemplation of the highest and of the best things. This is the ultimate human good. This is what human beings ultimately desire. This is what human beings do for their own sake and not for the sake of something else. So with all of that as background, the next question we might want to ask ourselves is, how does this view of human beings and this view of human goodness, how does this relate to politics? What does this have to do with politics? Well, one thesis that Aristotle advances that might seem at first glance a bit alien to us is that a human being cannot hope to achieve this highest good, a human being cannot hope to flourish unless he is a member of a political community. Now, in a Christian context, for example, this might seem like a somewhat strange idea. And in a subsequent class, I will talk a little bit about the relationship between Aristotle's idea and the Christian understanding of the same concept. But for our purposes here in this lecture, it's important to know that Aristotle does believe this. A human

The Individual in Relation to the Political

being cannot flourish except as a member of a political community. He tries to articulate this by saying the following and I quote, "The city or the political community is thus prior by nature to the household and to each of us, for the whole must of necessity be prior to the part." And what he means by this, I think, is that we cannot understand the part, in this case, the individual human being if he is cut off from the whole. So a somewhat funny example I like to use with my students, I say to them, "Look, imagine if you were to come up here to the podium and sort of chop off my hand and place it on the table in front of you. And you were to look at that thing sitting there. Is that still a human hand?" And Aristotle's answer to that question maybe somewhat surprisingly would be no. He might say it looks a lot like a human hand. We can see skin and bone and tissue and blood vessels and all of the other things that sort of resemble what a human hand would look like. But no, Aristotle would say that thing is not a human hand because it has been cut off, in this case literally, from the whole the human body of which it is a part. And if you want to extend the hand analogy to the individual, the same logic applies. The individual cannot do what he is meant to do apart from the political community of which he is a member. Now to draw some more analogies, just as the individual human being has one final end or goal, something that he is pursuing for its own sake, Aristotle says that we can understand the political community in the same way. We call this ultimate end of human life, eudaimonia or flourishing. And we call this ultimate end of political life the common good. Now just a brief note on the common good, because I think that this is a phrase we tend to throw around quite frequently sometimes, but we're not always clear precisely what it means. When we speak of the common good, students often want us to be speaking of something tangible. They want me as a teacher to be able to point to something and say the common good consists in this. But Aristotle's understanding of the common good is not in fact as something tangible. Aristotle defines the common good, and here I'm summarizing rather than quoting, but he defines the common good as a particular organization of the parts of a political community that allow each of its members to flourish. So the end of political life is not the attainment of something tangible like capturing this territory or putting this amount of money in the treasury, but it's rather to be understood as an ideal form of organization that allows each of the parts and each of the members to flourish in the manner proper to it.

The Organization of the Political Community

Now I'm going to have more to say about Aristotle's view of the political community as a whole, but Aristotle tells us that before we do that, we need to understand something about the component parts that make up this larger whole that we've called the political

community. Now I've obviously already mentioned the individual as maybe the primary and we might say the smallest part, but there are also other parts that we need to pay attention to. Aristotle notes that individuals begin to form relationships with others. It shouldn't surprise you to learn that he says that one of the most fundamental of those relationships is the relationship between male and female, between husband and wife, which will eventually issue in the relationship between parent and child.

Now it will surprise you perhaps to learn that Aristotle says that another of these most fundamental of human relationships is the relationship between master and slave. Now for purposes of this lecture, I don't have time to go into Aristotle's very complex and detailed views on slavery, but it is important for modern audiences to understand that Aristotle did in fact believe that slavery was an essential component of the proper functioning of a political community. If you are interested in learning more about Aristotle's views on that subject, I would encourage you to read book one of his famous work entitled *The Politics*, but these according to Aristotle are some of the most fundamental forms of human association, the relationship between male and female, and the relationship between master and slave. Now from these fundamental relationships, we build up ever larger parts. Male and female and the offspring that they produce end up forming what Aristotle calls a household. And households, according to Aristotle, come into existence for the sake of providing for the daily needs of their members food, water, shelter, clothing, etc. Now once we have a number of households that join together in one physical location, we have formed what Aristotle calls a village. This is a sort of group of households and this group of households being larger and capable of planning and looking to the future. These group of households, which he calls a village, exist, he says, for the provision of non-daily needs. Again, they can think beyond what is necessary for day to day life and they can look to the future. And finally, when a group of villages comes together, they form what Aristotle ultimately calls a political community. And Aristotle says in a sort of elegant and beautiful way that the political community comes into existence for the sake of life, but it ends up continuing to exist for the sake of living well, for the sake of the flourishing of its members, for the sake of providing for the common good.

Now, what more needs to be said? Well, there's a lot more that needs to be said, but Aristotle thinks one of the most important topics to pick up on from here is precisely how this political community ought to be organized so as to be best capable of achieving the common good.

And Aristotle takes up this subject, excuse me, by contrast with the views of his great mentor, the philosopher Plato. In Book Two of Aristotle's work called *The Politics*, he sets up his views on how the political community should be organized in contrast with the views of his great teacher.

And as Aristotle is often keen to do, he begins by looking for a point of agreement. He starts off by telling us, his audience, that both he and Plato agree that in order for the political community to achieve the common good, it is necessary that the political community be unified.

Having unity within a political community is of the utmost importance for both Plato and for Aristotle. But after this, we are introduced to an important point of disagreement. Plato tells us through the mouth of Socrates that a city or a political community is best unified by trying to make everyone the same and by trying to make everyone equal. If any of you are familiar with Plato's famous dialogue called the Republic, you know that in that dialogue, Socrates and a number of the characters to whom he is speaking propose constructing a political community where all property is held in common and frankly where even all women and children are held in common by all of the male members of the political community. And if this proposal strikes you as somewhat fanciful and maybe even absurd, Aristotle agrees with you. And he critiques this proposal of making everyone equal and making everyone the same through a couple of famous arguments. He points out, rightly so in my view, that if all property is held in common, no one individual will have any incentive to care for it. Human psychology is such that we tend to give greater care to those things that personally belong to us rather than to those things that are held in common. And so although Aristotle, like his great teacher, seeks to unify the city, he proposes doing so in a somewhat different way.

According to Aristotle, unity in the political community is achieved not by making everyone the same, not by making everyone equal, but by working with the natural diversity and even inequality that we find in a political community. By taking those diverse and unequal parts, having each of those persons and parts contribute their special talents and skills and in combination producing a unified political order. So now that we know Aristotle believes that unity in a political community is best achieved through a diversity of parts coming together and contributing to the good of the whole, I would like to conclude this lecture by talking about two more important points. The first is how precisely Aristotle thinks that this diversity is supposed to manifest itself in the structural organization of the community. And secondly, I would like to talk about some potential problems or difficulties with Aristotle's view. So first, the matter of the organization of the political community, Aristotle in a very systematic way outlines what the different possible forms of government may be. And by form of government, I mean and Aristotle means simply the way that power and political offices are distributed within a political community. Aristotle considers a number of possibilities. For example, he notes that we could give political power to one person, we could give it to a small group of people, we could give it to many people.

He also notes very practically that the goal or aim of the political community can look different in different places. Ideally, the political community, as we have already said, would be directed towards what we have called the common good. But he notes that in actual fact, in many existing political communities, the community is actually directed towards the private or selfish good of the ruler or rulers. So after outlining these various possibilities, Aristotle articulates his own view. But Aristotle doesn't have just one view, he has two. He speaks to us about what the ideal or best theoretical form of government may be. But he also tells us something about what he takes to be the best practical or practically possible form of government. So theoretically speaking or ideally speaking, Aristotle says that the best form of government is a form of government in which political power is concentrated in the hands of a few, but not just any small group of persons, but those persons within a political community that are the most virtuous amongst all the citizens. By having a small group of the most virtuous, make political decisions, Aristotle believes that it is most likely that the political community will be capable of attaining the common good. Now if this idea of concentrating political power in the hands of a small group makes you nervous, rest assured Aristotle considered this potential objection, it is true that he believes that political power in an ideal sense should be placed in the hands of a few virtuous men whom he calls aristocrats. But he also stresses that these aristocrats and the power that they wield and the decisions that they make must always be governed by what we might call the rule of law to ensure that these men cannot abuse the power entrusted to him. Now while this might be the ideal or best way to organize a political community, Aristotle understands that practically speaking, it may not always be possible to find such virtuous men and it may not always be practical to have the rest of the citizens agree to hand over power to a small group. So Aristotle says that practically speaking we would like to concentrate political power in the hands of the majority of citizens. This might be a view that is familiar to us, in fact it should be a view that is familiar to us.

But interestingly, Aristotle does not call this political arrangement democracy as we might be want to call it. Democracy according to Aristotle is problematic because it is a form of political organization in which people tend to wield their power selfishly. So what Aristotle envisions here is a system of political organization where power does yes reside in the people but where the people exercise that power not for their own selfish or particular interests but with the sake of the common good in mind. So that is a brief overview of Aristotle's understanding of the nature of the human person, of what it is that human beings desire and how it is that those persons and their desires find a place within the political community. To close I would just like

Conclusion

to draw your attention to a couple of potential problems and difficulties with Aristotle's understanding of politics and of the political community. The first is the problem of the relationship of what he calls the good man to the good citizen. What is it that a human being is supposed to do when a conflict makes a distinction, when a conflict drives a wedge between what is good for one to do as a human being as such and what is required of one by one's political community? What if a political community asks a citizen to do something that he knows is not good for him? It's questions like these that Aristotle raises although he does not necessarily give sufficient answers to those questions. I mentioned earlier the problem of slavery and the central role that slavery plays in Aristotle's understanding of the political community. If we reject the need for slavery as we must, what else is left to take away from Aristotle's understanding of political community and political organization can some of those other elements stand on their own even if the slavery is removed? And finally we need to avoid making the mistake as I often tell my students of Christianizing Aristotle. Aristotle comes in to the tradition of reasoning about ethics and politics that we will find in Christian moral and political philosophy, subsequent philosophers and most notably St. Thomas Aquinas adapt much of what Aristotle has to say to Christian teaching but we do have to understand that in the writings and teachings of Aristotle himself there are particular problems. Aristotle advises political rulers for example to take heed of the necessity of population control. He believes that population control is necessary to make sure that cities don't grow beyond a certain size. And his view of the human good, his view of intellectual contemplation of philosophical things might be understood as somewhat elitist. Although Aristotle has a very clear view of what the highest human good consists in, he also makes it very clear that this good is not going to be able to be attained by many human beings. People do need to possess a rather high level of intellectual skill and acumen in order to be able to attain these goods. So I conclude with some of those problems for the sake of reflection and also so that you may see how in subsequent lectures the history of political philosophy takes up those problems. [BLANK_AUDIO]

Study Questions

1. What is precisely meant by the Greek term Eudaimonia?
 - A) Flourishing
 - B) Peace
 - C) Happiness
 - D) Contemplation

2. In his Function Argument, Aristotle argues that human flourishing consists in:
 - A) Honor
 - B) Pleasure
 - C) Contemplation
 - D) Wealth

3. How does Aristotle define the common good?
 - A) The orientation of the parts of a society toward equality for all individuals
 - B) A particular organization of the parts of a political community that allows each of its members to flourish
 - C) A tangible goal toward which all the parts of a political community are oriented
 - D) The good of a society as a whole over the particular flourishing of its individuals

4. What do both Plato and Aristotle say a political community must have in order for it to achieve the common good?
 - A) Education
 - B) Wealth
 - C) Equality
 - D) Unity